

Episode 162: Long Ago... 101 1995 Part 20 Unexpected Additional Theatrical Works and "Dragon Quest VI" Descent in September

Actually, we currently have a cat at home. Due to various circumstances, we're having my wife's family cat homestay with us. Her name is "Mao." About 10 years old. Male. In human terms, maybe over 60? An old man.

If asked "dogs? cats?" I'm definitely team cat, but I'd never owned a cat before. Moreover, this "Mao" and I had been in a rival relationship for years - whenever I visited my wife's family home, I was completely unwelcome, always glared at with triangular eyes, plus threatened with "fuu~~, shah~~!"

So initially I wondered what would happen, but thanks to diligently preparing food and continuing to handle poop disposal, we're now super close. Bound by strong trust.

This "Mao" will return to my wife's family home soon - about one more week until farewell. Ah, what is this? This sadness... Somehow I can't imagine life without "Mao." Like lovers torn apart by fate.

Ah, what should I do... (cry). (continued)

Anyway.

"Tsuji-kun, do you have a moment?"

One day at the end of August, the section chief called me to a small room. This pattern usually means being scolded or assigned new work. "Work-wise, *Neighbourhood Story* TV broadcast is about to start and that's going fairly smoothly, and the new winter theatrical *Sailor Moon* just started when similarly called recently. So is this some scolding? Things I can think of... ah, there are some" - thinking such things while following the section chief to the small room.

"Well, it's about theatrical (works)"

"Yes? I'm already on the *Sailor Moon* theatrical, and poster work has started..."

"The next one. Next spring. Apparently they're doing *Dragon Ball*."

That's right. The story was making a theatrical *Dragon Ball* work for next year (1996) spring release. Moreover, not *Dragon Ball Z* that we'd been making for years, but new theatrical *Dragon Ball* without the "Z." With original manga serialisation ending in "Weekly Shonen Jump" and no more new original developments, apparently they'd return to origins and make a theatrical version following the original from the very beginning, around Goku's appearance. Title: *Dragon Ball: The Path to Power*.

"Well, Tsujita-kun, you're handling a lot, so I was thinking of putting someone else on it..."

"No, I'll do it, I'll do it, please let me do it!"

Actually, I'd been vaguely hearing about this theatrical version since early summer. And while the flow should have naturally settled on me as usual, somehow things were getting strange - production was floating ideas like having someone else do colour direction since I was overloaded. And since there was nobody suitable in-house, they'd call external colour direction staff.

I wasn't amused by that talk.

Certainly I was handling TV series *Neighbourhood Story* colour design (色彩設計), and currently working enthusiastically on theatrical *Sailor Moon SuperS: The 9 Sailor Soldiers Unite! Miracle of the Black Dream Hole* (←title still too long (cry)). But originally, for *Neighbourhood Story*, I was removed from individual episode colour direction so I could

handle other theatrical works, and honestly, for spring release works, the real busy period should be after *Sailor Moon SuperS* finishes in December. Certainly preparation periods overlap, but I was prepared to handle that somehow. And above all, I've supported theatrical *Dragon Ball Z* up to this point! - there was self-respect and pride, so I thought I'd do it whatever the situation!

"Ah? Really? You'll take it? Well, since the director is Yamauchi-kun, even saying 'someone else' would be difficult, so I was wondering what to do. I'm sure Yamauchi-kun will ask for Tsujita-kun anyway. I see, you'll do it. Ah, good!"

"Yes, I'll work hard!"

"And there's still more."

"Yes?"

"*Neighbourhood Story* will also be made as a double feature."

"Whaat!?"

What the heck! Nobody told me! Theatrical *Neighbourhood Story* - I didn't actually know this was moving.

"If Tsujita-kun takes *Dragon Ball*, this would be impossible, so just create character colours, just characters. Someone else will do the movie's main story colour direction."

Ah, I was had! Toei Animation's convention was that TV work theatrical versions are basically handled by the TV staff member for colour direction. So naturally that would be me, and the section chief knew this and brought up topics in this order. He knew I'd naturally want to do *Dragon Ball*, so I was completely had by the section chief (bitter

laugh). Hmm? Was it the section chief? Maybe someone higher up in production created such a scenario?

Anyway, 1995 thus became a super-packed year: 5 theatrical titles (1 title characters only), 1 TV series colour design, plus part-time work with 2 magazine cover colour directions, 1 laser disc jacket still colour direction, 1 PlayStation game opening colour direction and inspection...

"Oh, and one more thing. Do this too."

"Eh?"

The section chief handed me several rough drawings. These drawings, don't tell me...

"You know the game *Dragon Quest VI* coming out? Calendar for that. Since it's Toriyama Akira and Nakatsuru-kun is drawing it, do colour direction for this. And..."

"Eh? And?"

"And there's also colour direction for strategy guide art for the upcoming *Dragon Quest VI*, so please handle that too."

"...!"

Somehow the section chief piled various things on me in the confusion and left. After all that talk about theatrical works being difficult and *Neighbourhood Story* being tough, eh? What? This work is...

So amazingly, even "Dragon Quest" work came my way!

(11.04.12)